

Where is your job taking you? Read on to know the rules of the game

Neelanjana Gautam

James Altucher is no stranger to the world of blogging, startups, and entrepreneurial innovation. In one of his posts, he talks about gaming the system: When he was younger, he couldn't last more than two to three days at a job before plotting an exit route. He would figure out how to build from his current job so he could either have an even better job, make more money, or start his own business.

So there is a story there, and if you are one of those, you, too, can make the cut.

Take the case of Scott Moeller, Ph.D., a Silicon Valley technocrat who's apparently doing what he does best: "I insert into a new workforce, find something technical that is in sore need of fixing, and then go through the next couple of years building momentum, getting buy in, and solving the issue. Once done, I often find myself less motivated as I've learned what I had set out for, and the cost-benefit tradeoff leads me to look outside the company for my next opportunity."

This behavioral approach might seem shaky and challenging on the surface, but the modern-day workforce is taking a leaf out of this basic attitudinal shift and turning it into a full-blown case of career overhaul.

Moeller, who has been doing unilateral "tours of duty" for several years, finds this an interesting shift in career dynamics. Well, for the uninitiated, this strategy requires ambition, social-reintroduction, and pecking order discovery, not to forget the emotional reorientation needed to adjust to the ever-shifting workspace.

Simplifying Tour of Duty

The idea of tour of duty is that, a mutually beneficial contract is drawn up between the employer and the prospective employee. The employer has the challenging problem of retaining and keeping the employee motivated within a relatively known timeline, typically two years. The prospective employee is determining what she could learn and what career advancement may result, and if interested, she signs up for a tour of duty. Once complete, however, the employee may (will) leave the company for the next business.

Corporate paradigm shift

The corporate landscape is changing. Employees no longer come with lifetime warranties. Employers are also happy to put a sell-by date label on the recruit. Experts believe that no longer can one build a fast moving company with lifelong employment contracts.

The incentive structures that once fueled single-company careers in the past are slowly disappearing, which signify that high-performance, high-potential employees are now more mobile, and often look for interesting new work outside their current employment.

How does this mutual investment work?

This kind of alliance is seemingly bereft of any emotional involvement, but it cashes in on the value of reciprocity and trust. It aims to build a strong relationship, although with a finite shelf life. For e.g., one gets an engaged employee who produces tangible results for the company, and, in the process, amps up her skill-sets for reuse and recycling. That way, the employee is continuously pushing frontiers for professional development and also for personal gratification.

This raises an interesting perspective to “employee development.” It may seem that the company is giving more control to the high performer to make herself more marketable, only to let her go after the contract dries out, but it does have its auxiliary benefits.

Employees who work on this design bring in new ideas and knowledge beyond the immediate working environment. Such cross-pollination results in more productive work space and adds to the intellectual capital of an organization. By trading lifelong employment, this way the employee makes herself lifelong employable.

Propelling factors

So what is making one switch? No doubt, enhancing skill-set is acting as one of the push buttons. It could also be an entrepreneurial opportunity or a breakthrough assignment that could catapult the employee significantly in the organizational order of things. Or, it could be something like building an idea, launching a new product, or may be a showstopper code! And of course, one cannot rule out the financial motives.

Ehsan Aryafar, Ph.D., who moved to Silicon Valley two years back, says that different people have different thresholds for making a switch, and in most cases, it stems from financial rewards. This trend is more apparent in startups where, as soon as the stocks get vested, they move on to the next venture. But the feeling of working at different places, meeting new people, and acquiring new skills has its own plus.

HR angle and expert talk

The tour of duty could also be a means to attract and recruit top talents. In a competitive marketplace where recruiting and retaining talents is a challenge, this strategy may have an edge. And if laid out properly, this could be a win-win for both. The company gets an entrepreneurial employee for a time frame, and the employee in turn moves a step forward and builds her brand value.

Brand Builder Strategist Edward Leaman, who teaches at Stanford, makes an interesting observation: “I think so much of this might depend on what the skill is and what the ambition of the person is. Whilst there are indeed specialist skills like computer programming, many skills of management are developed and nurtured over time.”

This is particularly true when the employee is leading from the front, collaborating, communicating, managing people, and working on projects with a longer lifecycle. These are not necessarily jobs with a quick fix solution.

He further adds, “In an era of subject matter expertise, the question may well be how the subject and the expert combine to provide value for a company, and also how the individual sees and wants her potential and future to become realized and unfolded.”